

BEFORE

The Maya, Aztecs, and Incas had the most advanced cultures of all the peoples living in America before the arrival of the Spanish.

THE MAYA

The **Maya** c. 140–41 had lived in parts of Mexico, Guatemala, Belize, and Honduras for more than 1,000 years before the first great flowering of their culture c. 300 CE.

THE AZTECS

The **Aztecs** are thought to have arrived in **central Mexico** in the 13th century, either from northern Mexico or from the southwest United States, but their exact origins are unclear.

THE INCAS

Beginning as a tribe in Cuzco in the 12th century, the Incas **spread** throughout the **Andes** regions of modern-day Peru, Ecuador, and Chile.

MISSISSIPPIAN CULTURE

Mississippian culture of the **southeast United States** had much in common with Mesoamerican cultures: **agriculture** based on **corn**, towns with wide plazas, and giant ceremonial mounds.



Carving on stone lintel at Yaxchilan

This carving shows the accession rituals of the ruler Bird Jaguar. His wife Balam-Ix, sitting opposite, performs a blood sacrifice by drawing a rope through her tongue.

HOW WE KNOW

MAYA ASTRONOMY

The pyramid of Kukulcán at Chichén Itzá is a solar calendar, built on top of an earlier lunar calendar. The pyramid is full of symbolism: the four stairways leading to the central platform at the top each have 91 steps, totaling 364—added to the central platform this makes 365, which is the number of days in the solar year. On either side of each stairway are nine terraces, which makes 18 on each face: a number that equals the number of months in the Maya solar calendar. The facing of each terrace contains 52 panels, representing the 52-year cycle during which the solar and religious calendars become realigned.



Pre-Columbian Americas

Characterized by their advances in astronomy and the arts, the Maya, Aztecs, and Incas had the richest and most complex societies in pre-Columbian America. Although distinct cultures, they shared similar traditions, including ritualized religious worship and a belief in the value of education and spirituality.

Whereas the Aztecs and Incas subjugated neighboring peoples to create powerful empires, the Maya never formed an empire, nor did they have a single ruler or dominant capital city. They were a loose federation of city-states bound together by a common language, culture, and religion. The priest-rulers, who maintained power through their superior education and contacts with the gods, led the Maya to extraordinary achievements in mathematics, astronomy, architecture, fine arts, engineering, and writing.

Religious practices

Along with the Aztecs and Incas, the Maya had a pantheon of gods, and their religious practices were based on their interpretation of the cycles of nature. These gods were rarely discrete entities but instead combined a wide variety of forms and ideas. They could be both young and old, take both human and animal forms, and often had a counterpart of the opposite sex.

The supreme deity of the Maya was Itzam Ná, who was represented iconically as an old man; he was the inventor of writing and patron of learning and sciences. His wife, IxChel, was goddess of the old moon, as well as of weaving, medicine, and childbirth.

Religious rituals were performed to satisfy the gods and ensure order in the world. Ceremonies usually began with fasting and abstinence, followed by offerings of food,

Quetzalcoatl mask

This mask is thought to represent the Aztec god Quetzalcoatl, who is often depicted as a feathered serpent. It is made of cedar wood, covered in turquoise mosaic, and the teeth are made of shell.



ornaments, dancing, and an occasional human sacrifice, although not on the scale of the Aztecs (see right). During the ceremonies the priests might impersonate the gods, or use hallucinogens to enhance their powers of divination. Finally, there would be feasting and drunkenness.

Later Maya civilization

Around 800 CE, some lowland Maya city-states went into decline, and by 900 CE had all but collapsed. Many explanations have been proposed for this, ranging from natural causes, such as disease or climate change, to soil exhaustion, war, or loss of control by the priest-aristocracy, but no theory can be proven absolutely.

After c. 900 all the main Maya centers were in the northern part of the Yucatán. One, Chichén Itzá, was founded in the second half of the 8th century by a confederation of groups drawn from the Maya lowlands and the Itzá people, whose origins are unknown. The city, which appears to have experimented with new rituals and forms of shared government, was a thriving community in the 9th and 10th centuries, but collapsed after 1050. The architecture of Chichén Itzá (see pp.212–13) is strikingly similar to that of Tula, the capital of the Toltecs 40 miles (65 km) to the north of Mexico City, which flourished at around the same time. It is not exactly clear which of these cities influenced the other, but there must have been

extensive cultural and trade links across central and southern parts of Mexico at this time.

The Aztec Empire

The Aztecs—or Mexico, as they called themselves—were the most powerful people in the Valley of Mexico during the 15th and 16th centuries. Their capital, Tenochtitlán (now Mexico City), was founded in the 14th century on an island in Lake Texcoco. The marshes that surrounded the city might seem an unpromising

“We beheld... cities and towns on the water... it was like the things of enchantment.”

BERNAL DIAZ DE CASTILLO, ON ENTERING THE AZTEC CAPITAL TENOCHTITLÁN, 1519

environment, but the Aztecs were expert managers of water. They not only built dams to trap the fresh water from the rivers that flowed into the lake, but also grew a wide variety of crops on *chinampas*, fertile artificial islands created in the shallow lake.

Aztec society was class-based, with nobility at the top and slaves at the bottom. Education seems to have



Stone sacrificial altar

The *cuauhxicalli*, which translates as “eagle gourd vessel,” was used by Aztecs to make their most sacred offerings—human hearts.